

magazine

DALIT
HISTORY
MONTH

literaryreview
Essential reading from
writers, scholars, artists

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Ibrahim Mahama at KMB

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ILLUSTRATION: HITESH SONAR



Kunal Purohit

Ankit Pandey* was rushing to catch a train from Mumbai’s Malad station last month, when a sight halted him in his tracks. From the railway bridge, he could see a group of men offering *namaaz* (prayers) just outside the railway platform.

Pandey, 22, a worker in the Hindutva outfit Bajrang Dal, was incensed. He shot a 33-second video of the men praying, with his voiceover – “Will a Hindu be allowed to do this?” He added a song, a menacing chorus with pulsating beats, and uploaded it to Instagram through the local account of a leaderless Hindutva outfit called the Sakal Hindu Samaj (SHS).

He tagged four other similar accounts with a combined following of over 3.7 lakh followers. It took him less than 10 minutes to shoot and upload. But overnight, the post blew up.

Tens of thousands shared it and agreed with his outrage. Senior Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders latched on, and in 24 hours, Railways authorities had booked three people for ‘trespassing railway property’. Pandey’s post still remains on Instagram – with over 54,000 likes and more than a million views.

Once a hub for vacation photos and aspirational lifestyle content, Instagram in India is now evolving into a space filled with political messaging, ranging from cheeky memes to hate-driven propaganda. Accelerating this shift is parent company Meta’s decision last year to push more political and news content towards users, including content from those they don’t follow. “We may recommend political content from accounts people don’t already follow based on personalised signals. If you want to see more or less political content, you can change your Political Content Control setting at any time,” says a Meta spokesperson.

India is Instagram’s largest market in the world, with around 481 million users. But with the platform becoming the

mainstay of India’s political campaigning, there are also concerns. While disinformation through AI-generated content and hate-filled videos continues to flourish, critical voices might be getting silenced.

Such a trend holds immense significance for India. After all, in both neighbouring Nepal and Bangladesh – the sites of Gen Z protests which dislodged governments – Instagram emerged as a key source of information for protesters. Apart from posting content that stoked the protests, users in both countries also leveraged it to coordinate among themselves and create safe channels of communication.

Catching Gen Z

In India, the platform has seen a clear uptick in usage. Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism’s 2025 Digital News Report captures the scale of this shift: while 55% of Indians preferred YouTube as their news source, 37% now turn to Instagram – the largest rise in news consumption recorded across any platform.

According to Raqib Naik, executive director of the Washington D.C.-based Center for the Study Of Organized Hate (CSOH), which tracks hate and disinformation on social media platforms, Instagram’s design and features – its infinite scrolling, the autoplay reels and an algorithm that curates your feed – make the app a perfect fit for political content. “Instagram’s visual grammar lends itself well to messaging that is highly emotive, simplified, and easy to circulate at scale,” he says.

Academic and satirist Maduri Kakoti, known online as ‘Dr. Medusa’, agrees. “Even though it didn’t mean to start off as a politically-influential tool, its very design makes Instagram tailor-made for political messaging and propaganda,” she says.

Political campaign managers have taken note. Talha Rashid, a Delhi-based political consultant and strategist who has worked across party lines for state and central polls, says Instagram is no longer an afterthought for political

FROM SELFIES TO SLOGAN

How Instagram is becoming India’s newest political battleground, rewarding outrage, muting dissent and rewriting visibility



leaders. “It is now the first platform we think about.”

Established politicians, he adds, are constantly looking at innovative ways to boost their Instagram game. “Earlier, most politicians would just post about their daily routines, the meetings they held, etc. But now they are looking at collaborating with influencers or becoming a part of viral trends on the Internet,” Rashid says.

The campaign mounted by Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, seeking a record third-term in power, demonstrates this. Standing out among his media interviews are his conversations with influencers – including one with financial content creator Sharique Samsudheen. The



influencer has over 1.63 million subscribers on YouTube – three times more than his following on Instagram. Yet, a short clip of his interview with Vijayan, where the leader talks about going to jail – with AI-generated visuals of a young Vijayan in

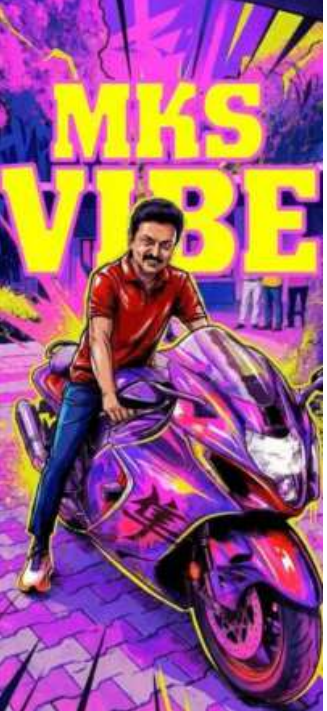
According to Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism’s 2025 Digital News Report, while 55% of Indians prefer YouTube as their news source, 37% now turn to Instagram

TOP NEWS SOURCES

	2024	2025
YouTube:	54%	55%
Instagram:	33%	37%
Facebook:	35%	36%
Telegram:	20%	22%
X:	13%	16%

(Source: Digital News Report, 2025)

prison, washing his clothes, taking on the jailer – has 1.4 million views on Instagram, with 73,000 users liking it. The original 41-minute interview on YouTube, meanwhile, has 229,000 views and just over 8,600 likes.



Vijayan’s rivals are also adopting a similar strategy. Jayan G. Nath, digital media campaign head of Twenty20 – an NDA constituent contesting in 19 Assembly constituencies in Kerala – says the party’s social media campaign is primarily Instagram-driven. “Our focus on Instagram is because it is the best platform to influence young voters,” Nath says, adding that short videos, rather than longer videos on YouTube, are “the most consumed” of all content.

Next door, in Tamil Nadu, Chief Minister M.K. Stalin’s campaign seems to be taking lessons. Stalin’s campaign has launched an Instagram-focused drive, called ‘Vibe with MKS’, where he is seen having

Snapshots of social media posts and memes put out by political parties recently; and campaigning scenes in Tamil Nadu. (INSTAGRAM, PTI)

informal conversations with influencers, as well as with musicians, while donning casual T-shirts and trousers, ditching his trademark white shirt and *veshti*. While the ‘Vibe with MKS’ page itself has just over 13,000 followers, a video of Stalin meeting two child influencers – brothers Deva and Jiva – has garnered over 5.4 million views.

Journalist and Tamil YouTuber Rangaraj Pandey, who runs the popular political channel ‘Chanakyaa’, says such an emphasis on Instagram is a result of the State’s demographics – nearly a fifth of Tamil voters belong to Gen Z. “Till 15 years ago, a political campaign would almost entirely be fought on the ground,” Pandey says. “Now, at least 40% of the campaign has shifted to social media platforms. Young voters don’t want to listen to monotonous speeches at rallies. Instead, they will watch a 60-second reel on Instagram encapsulating the essence of that speech.”

Pandey also points to the popularity of actor C. Joseph Vijay and his party, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), as being a major reason behind the DMK’s social media push. TVK has been doubling down on its youth support base – Vijay boasts the party has the country’s “largest social media army” and calls them “virtual warriors” of the party.

To AI or not to AI

Political parties are also increasingly relying on AI, to be able to cater to the endless appetites of social media users.

The Congress’ Tamil Nadu campaign, for instance, has created an AI-generated mascot, a young bespectacled woman named Rakkamma, who looks into the camera and publicises the Congress’ promises with the hashtag ‘Rakkamma Talks’.

CONTINUED ON
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▲
Lion capital from the Pillar of
Emperor Ashoka. (GETTY IMAGES)

attends to the idea of India, from the very inception of the lyric in Tagore’s mind in 1911. Krishna also worked with the historian Sugata Bose to tease out the subtle differences, both melodic and verbal, between the less well-known version of the anthem used by Bose’s ancestor Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose for his patriotic activities, and that given by Tagore and formally adopted at Independence.

These experiments, combining archival research with musical creativity, not to mention linguistic dexterity, have led Krishna to write his latest book on India’s national symbols. Never one to shy away from intervening in public discourse, he sets out to examine, explain, and extoll not just the four symbols – the flag, the emblem, the motto, and the anthem – but also adds a fifth chapter, on the Preamble to the Constitution. With characteristic intellectual ambition and a sense of political urgency, Krishna doesn’t merely explore what each of them means. Rather he takes us back to the debates in the Constituent Assembly where these symbols were chosen and adopted, and points to our present circumstances which necessitate recalling the lofty vision that went into the making of modern India.

The book combines a scholar’s rigour with a citizen’s anxiety, returning us to the founding moment and its promises at the very juncture when the foundations of free India threaten to collapse. As always, Krishna puts his erudition in service of his activism, holding up the aspirations of the past to critique the failures of the present.

The four national symbols are each one a combination of the ancient and the modern. The Tricolour flag evokes the many – rather than merely three – religious communities enfolded into the Indian nation, even while placing the Ashokan Dhamma Chakra at the centre. The emblem is adapted from the Ashokan Lion Capital, and the Sanskrit motto ‘Satyameva Jayate’ is taken from a verse in the *Mundaka Upanisad*. The Preamble was adopted by the Constituent Assembly towards the very end of the drafting of the Constitution, in November 1949, but the text evolved over two decades, from 1928 onwards, with its most significant elements contributed by Motilal Nehru, Jawaharlal Nehru, Mahatma Gandhi, B.N. Rau, and Babasaheb Ambedkar. Krishna is meticulous in documenting the complex and contentious processes whereby consensus was achieved around these symbols.

In my own writing about the symbolic repertoire of independent India, I focused on classical texts and artefacts and their historical contexts which attracted and inspired the founders, particularly Gandhi, Rabindranath and Abanindranath Tagore, Nehru, and Ambedkar. But Krishna goes a step further, including in his account the doubts, mistakes, disagreements, and controversies surrounding choices that had to be made amidst the turmoil of Independence and Partition. And more importantly, he continually links the semantics of the symbols to our contemporary condition. He seeks, through the reinterpretation of our tangible symbols, a reinvigoration of our intangible democracy.

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The writer is a professor at the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies, New Delhi.

Hauntings of history

Ali Smith pairs imagination with urgency in her politically charged new novel

Sanjay Sipahimalani

Among contemporary novelists, Ali Smith stands out for her engagement with the political moment, as well as with her fondness for wordplay and what it reveals about the language we use. Her *Seasonal Quartet* (2016-20), for example, responded to post-Brexit Britain and is shot through with themes of resilience and renewal. More recently, *Gliff* (2024) was set in a near future of high-tech surveillance and linked the precarious state of the natural world with that of language itself.

Smith’s new novel, *Glyph*, can be read as a companion piece to *Gliff*. The earlier novel takes its name from the Scots word for a passing glimpse or a fright, whereas this volume focuses on a ‘glyph’ as a mark or sign, linked to a hieroglyph. The two books are connected symbolically, with resonances in the form of recurring motifs and stories within stories.

As with much of Smith’s work, plot is hardly the point with *Glyph*. Instead, patterns of connection, the play of speech, and reflections on how we live take centre stage. At one point, for instance, a character confesses: “Like everybody else now I’m a person who can cope with several screens.” Later, in the kitchen, she “grated the extra cheese into a bowl and watched it come apart from its block with something like a heightened understanding of what it might mean to be both whole and shredded”.

Surreal and the real

The story, such as it is, is narrated non-chronologically and revolves around episodes in the lives of two sisters, Petra and Patricia, both of whom grapple with the impact of their mother’s untimely death as well as their overactive imaginations. When they were children, they were haunted by the harrowing story of a soldier who was flattened by a tank, leading them to invent his ghost, named Glyph. Years later, Petra finds her bedroom trashed and believes she is being haunted by a spectral horse related to a family legend about a World War I deserter who tried to save a blind charger.

Glyph engages directly with the wreckage of war, be it in Gallipoli or Gaza, with characters being flattened both literally and symbolically. As it progresses, it touches upon a surveillance state that bristles at protest, with one character facing arrest for a minor act of resistance. The narrative also comments on the flattening impact of AI: we’re told that Patricia was employed as a spotter of AI text, rewriting it to make it sound more human. However, she’s replaced by an AI assistant, “because artificial intelligence is now thought to be better than any human not just at spotting artificial intelligence in advertising copy but also at

rewriting it to make it sound more human”.

In this way, Smith keeps the proceedings light and nimble. There are frequent puns and playfulness, pointing out that language can represent reality but also distort it. The surreal is mixed with the real, and characters discuss other stories and books, including – nod, wink – the earlier *Gliff*. Such game-playing continues throughout: at one stage, a feeling of absence is referred to as a “prosthetic limbo”. If you groan at that, this book may not be for you.

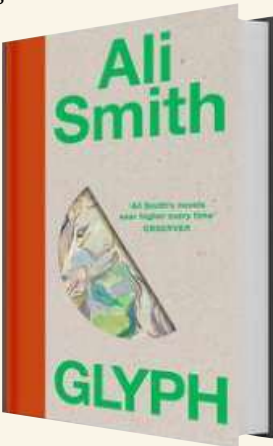
Fiction and memory

For Smith, the antidote to a “flattened” world, whether by tanks or by technology, is the enduring, regenerative power of narrative. She reminds us that a story is a force “old as the hills itself and as brand new as everything that manages, against the odds, to grow fresh and new on those old hills”. Within these layers of fiction and memory, her characters find the resilience to remain whole even in a culture that would prefer them shredded.

In this sense, *Glyph* acts as a counterweight to what Frederic Jameson termed the “depthlessness” of modern life. It indicates that a heightened imagination is not an escape from reality, but an essential tool for truly engaging with it, accompanied by a radical form of care.

Pay attention to the history you are making in the present, Smith suggests, or it will return to haunt you.

▲
The reviewer is based in Mumbai.



Glyph
Ali Smith
Hamish Hamilton
₹899



▲
Glyph can be read as a companion piece to Ali Smith’s 2024 novel *Gliff*. (GETTY IMAGES)

READING THE REPUBLIC

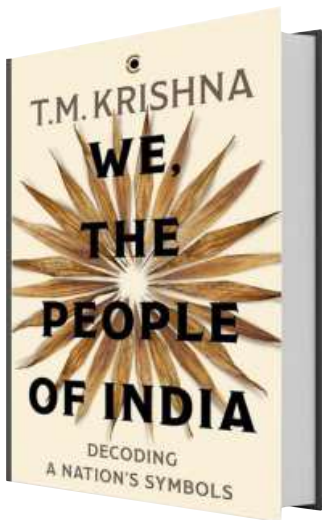
Combining a scholar’s rigour with a citizen’s anxiety, T.M. Krishna’s book revisits the foundational debates of modern India

Ananya Vajpeyi

Over the past decade, I have spent time reading the edicts of the Mauryan emperor Ashoka (304-232 BCE) with philologists and teaching my students to appreciate them. In our discussions, we employed modern translations. It never occurred to me to imagine how they would sound if uttered aloud, since they are composed in ancient languages – Prakrit, Aramaic, and Classical Greek; and inscribed in ancient scripts – Brahmi, Kharoshthi, and Greek. Much of interest in the edicts has been in their archaeological excavation, their decipherment, and their geographical spread across the subcontinent. Romila Thapar’s pathbreaking work in the 1960s was focused on reconstructing the political history of the Mauryan Empire, and establishing Ashoka as a historical figure, distinct from the plethora of literary representations and Buddhist hagiographies produced in the first millennium.

This slow-moving field of inquiry changed when T.M. Krishna, with guidance from Gopalkrishna Gandhi, decided to figure out not only how the words would be pronounced, but also how they might be set to melody and sung. He collaborated with leading scholars, notably Nayanjot Lahiri, Naresh Keerthi, and the Buddhist monk Shravasti Dhammika. The result was ‘The Edict Project’, which aims to “reimagine the edicts in musical form”. It was launched in 2020 and housed, appropriately, at Ashoka University. The renditions sung by Krishna, in all three classical languages, have a haunting beauty. He gives a profound emotional and aesthetic resonance to the moral values of non-violence, pacifism, justice, and tolerance with which the great monarch sought to imbue his sovereignty.

It was Gopal Gandhi, to whom *We the People of India: Decoding a Nation’s Symbols* is dedicated, who had earlier encouraged Krishna to revisit the national anthem ‘Jana Gana Mana’, written by Rabindranath Tagore. Krishna realised it was



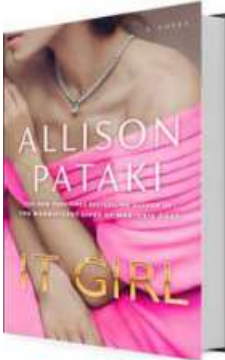
We, the People of India: Decoding a Nation’s Symbols
T.M. Krishna
Context/Westland
₹899

worth restoring the complete song with five stanzas, of which only the first one is sung as the official anthem. Krishna renders it slowly and mellifluously, its plangent lyrics conveying not only the glory, but also the pathos that

BROWSER

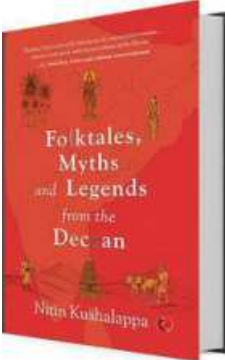
It Girl

Allison Pataki
Ballantine Books
₹940
The dramatic story of America’s first ‘It girl’, model and actor Evelyn Nesbit, is vividly rendered in this novel. In 1906, Nesbit found herself at the centre of the ‘trial of the century’ after her husband killed a prominent architect with whom she had a past relationship.



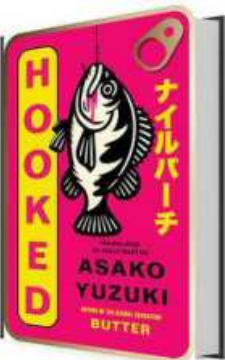
Folktales, Myths and Legends from the Deccan

Nitin Kushalappa
Rupa
₹295
This collection brings alive the oral traditions of the Deccan with stories of local heroes, folk deities and forbidden lovers. It also includes an ethnographic essay on the ancient tradition of the seven mother-goddesses worshipped in the region.



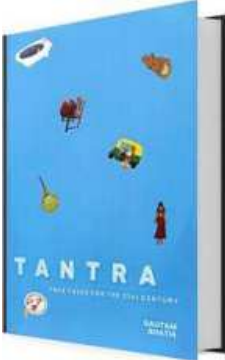
Hooked

Asako Yuzuki, trs Polly Barton
Fourth Estate
₹699
Written in 2015, this unsettling story explores the thin line between friendship and obsession of two women. Like her previous bestseller *Butter*, here too Asako focuses on food and the pressures of modern society in Japan. Several of her works have been adapted for TV.



Unpunchtantra: Folk Tales for the 21st Century

Gautam Bhatia
Storybook Press
₹599
An updated edition of his 1998 book *Punchtantra*, where he contemporises the original fables, Bhatia now takes a jab at the current state of democracy, Artificially Intelligent bureaucrats and more.



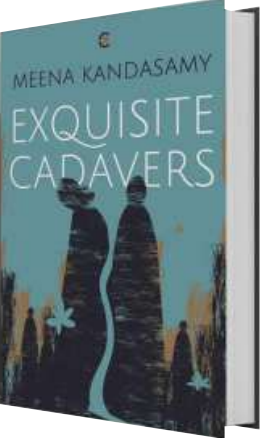
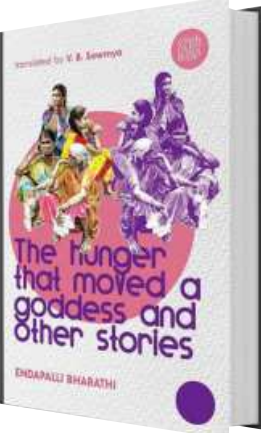
Siddhesh Gautam

I am still reading to learn. But this year, I am learning to heal. Healing is not always soft. Sometimes, it comes with a lot of pain. Sometimes, it burns before it soothes. Through these books I'm not just gathering my scattered pieces of history, I am also sharpening them.



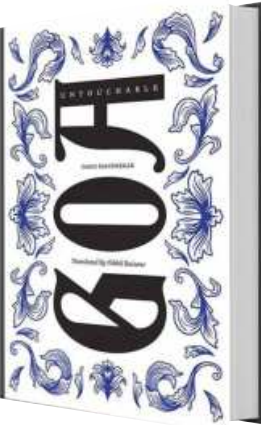
The Hunger That Moved a Goddess and Other Stories (Hyderabad Book Trust) by Endapalli Bharathi, trs. V.B. Sowmya

Bharathi's stories are demographically rooted in rural Andhra Pradesh, but ideologically they travel far beyond geography. They centre women's lives from Dalit communities with an honesty that refuses pity. There is hunger, yes, but also defiance, humour, and small, everyday rebellions. The "goddess" in the title doesn't sit in temples; she walks in bodies that endure and resist. What struck me most is how quietly radical these short stories are. And in between these lives, almost gently, the book teaches you how to eat, how to cook, how to remember through food. Recipes and eating habits appear not as instructions but as stories — of survival, of scarcity, of community.

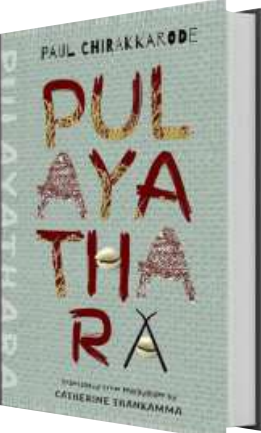


Exquisite Cadavers (Context/Westland) by Meena Kandasamy

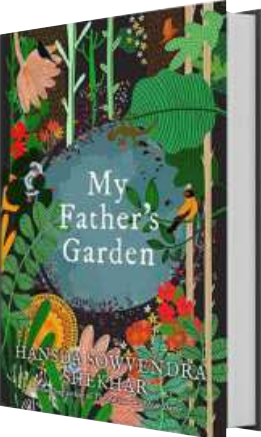
This is not a conventional novel. It is not biographical or fictional. It is fragmented, self-aware, almost impatient with storytelling itself. Kandasamy weaves together multiple narratives: a love story, a political landscape, a writer's struggle with form. The title itself suggests bodies — broken, rearranged, reimagined. It feels like a response to violence, not by narrating it cleanly, but by refusing coherence. The book asks: how do you write when language itself has been wounded?



Untouchable Goa (Panther's Paw Publication) by Dadu Mandrekar, trs. Nikhil Baisane
Mandrekar disrupts the postcard image of Goa. Through essays and reflections, he exposes the deep entrenchment of caste in Goan society — within Catholic communities, within everyday social structures, within spaces that claim modernity. The writing is sharp, almost journalistic at times, but never distant from storytelling. It forces you to confront how caste adapts, survives, and hides behind narratives of progress, liberalism, and tourism.



Pulayathara (OUP India) by Paul Chirakkaroode, trs. Catherine Thankamma
Set in Kerala, *Pulayathara* documents the life of the Pulaya community with a depth that feels archival and intimate at once. It engages with landlessness, bonded labour, and generational trauma, but also with community, memory, and continuity. The novel doesn't rush; it lingers. It allows you to sit with the weight of history. What stays is not just the suffering, but the persistence of life despite it.



My Father's Garden (Speaking Tiger) by Hansda Sowvendra Shekhar

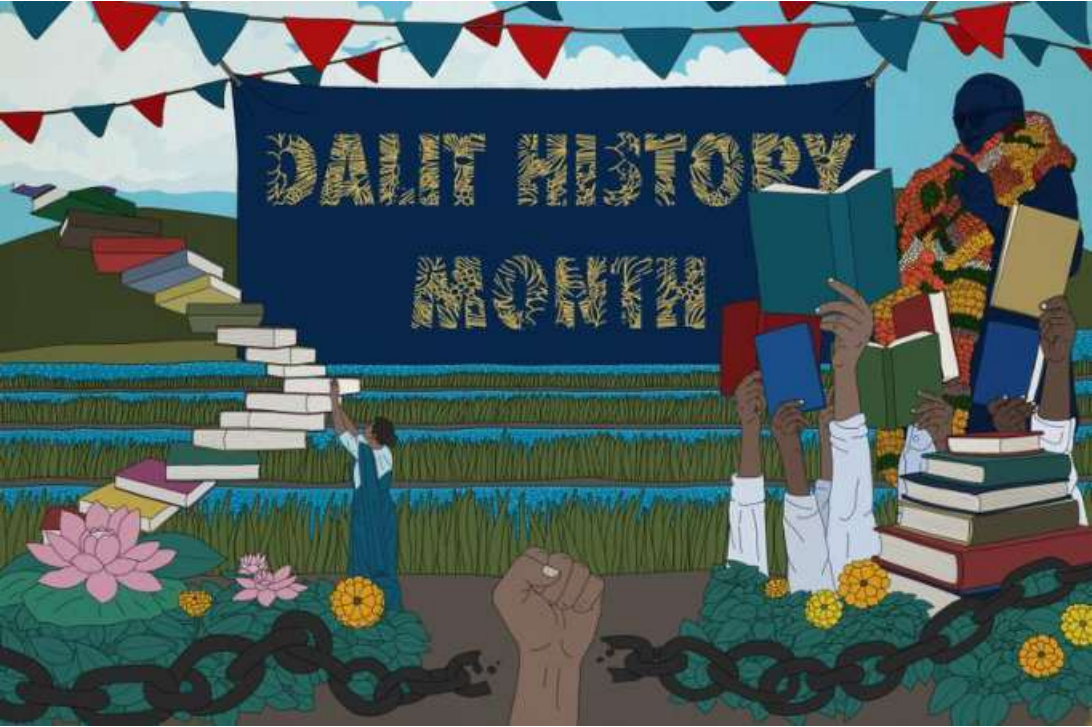
This collection of stories is deeply tied to Santhal Adivasi life. Shekhar writes about land, family, migration, and loss with a quiet, observational style. There is no spectacle here — just layered, lived realities. The "garden" becomes a metaphor for belonging and rupture. Development, displacement, and memory intersect in ways that feel both personal and political. It made me think about how landscapes hold histories we are often taught to ignore.

These books didn't just meet me where I am. They pushed me further. To learn more. To heal more.

The writer is an artist, thinker, and Ambedkarite.

The canon of Dalit literature in English and regional languages has expanded greatly

ROOTS OF RESISTANCE



CREDIT: SIDDHESH GAUTAM

Team Magazine

Every year since 2015, India has observed Dalit History Month to reclaim history through the perspectives of those long marginalised and oppressed.

Across the 20th and 21st centuries, Dalit writing has steadily grown, reshaping the literary landscape. A powerful canon has emerged in English as well as in many regional languages, articulating anger, despair, struggle, love, and resistance, while also giving voice to the innermost lives of people. These stories have become increasingly visible and widely read, aided in part by India's growing culture of translation.

These are all stories of diverse individuals with distinct personhoods. Reading them matters not only because they reflect lived experience, but because they challenge dominant histories, which have often been written by those with cultural and economic power. Whether fiction or non-fiction, forms whose boundaries are often blurred, Dalit writing is visceral and unforgettable.

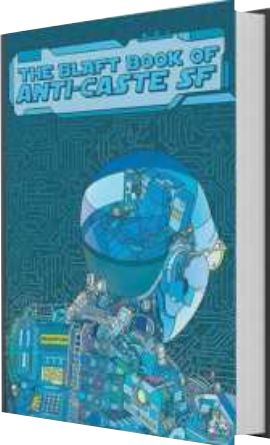
We asked some of India's most remarkable Dalit writers and artists to recommend a book. The roots of Dalit literature continue to deepen and spread. What we have here is only a small glimpse of that vast and growing tradition.

Yashica Dutt
Journalist, author, speaker

Writing on caste has been ubiquitous in the last decade. But only a fraction of it has come from writers from marginalised and oppressed caste backgrounds. Given the rapid transformation of caste into a stomping ground for several dominant caste anthropologists, social scientists, and historians eager to "study how the other lives", one of the books I have enjoyed immensely is *The Blaft Book of Anti-Caste SF* (Blaft Publications). An



anthology of short stories spanning science fiction, fantasy, and magical realism, this volume includes voices of caste oppressed writers as well as others who have incorporated anti-caste perspectives into their writing. The spectre of caste is so immense and all-encompassing that often, non-fiction alone fails to reach its farthest contours. This is where this delicious anthology comes in: naming feelings that often seem unnameable, identifying practices that resist categorisation, and drawing the reader into a world that caste-oppressed people inhabit all their lives — yet one that mostly goes unnoticed, or is wilfully ignored.



Bama
Writer, poet, teacher

S. Karuppasamy's first book, *Naan Loco Pilot Aana Kathai* (The Story of Becoming a Loco Pilot; Tathagata Publishing House), is gripping, yet written in simple language in Tamil. It narrates Karuppasamy's efforts, disappointments, failures, pain, and challenges, leaving the reader both surprised and moved. His life challenges the negative mindset of leading just another life, and instead affirms the idea of living "a life of choice."



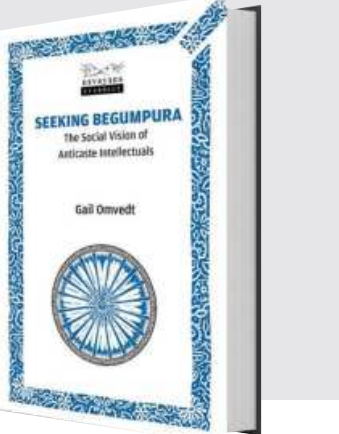
Born to Dalit parents in a small hamlet, with little access to education and without social status or a strong economic and political background, Karuppasamy achieved his dream through his own efforts. A native of Sembatti in Virudhunagar district in Tamil Nadu, Karuppasamy studied at an Industrial Training Institute. He joined as a trackman in Kollam and now works as a loco pilot in Chennai.

There are many books such as his that have not been translated yet. I hope they will become available in the English so that they reach a wider group of readers.



Somnath Waghmare
Documentary filmmaker

Gail Omvedt's *Seeking Begumpura* (Navayana) is a fascinating study of India's anti-caste thinking. It examines the ideas of Bhakti saints such as Ravidas and Kabir, as well as reformers such as Jyotirao Phule and B.R. Ambedkar. The book presents an alternative history that highlights the voices and struggles of marginalised communities. What I liked most is how it links spirituality with social and political resistance. The concept of 'Begumpura', a utopian society free from caste, inequality, and suffering, is both inspiring and thought-provoking. Omvedt demonstrates that these visions were not just religious ideals; they were also strong critiques of social hierarchy. Her writing makes complex ideas easy to understand without oversimplifying them. This book provides a new viewpoint on Indian history, emphasises the importance of anti-caste thought, and encourages readers to think critically about equality and justice while introducing them to voices often ignored.



Meena Kandasamy
Poet, writer, translator, activist

Sharankumar Limbale's *Sanatan* (Penguin), translated from

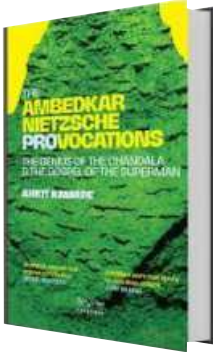
the Marathi by Paromita Sengupta, is a novel that does the near-impossible: it tells a gripping, tenderly narrated story of Maharwada spanning over a century while simultaneously arming the reader with the intellectual tools to dismantle the caste system. Through his characters, Limbale unpacks the origin myths of the so-called eternal order. He shows how Brahminism perpetuates its ideology through mythology, and counters it with narratives drawn from Dalit and Adivasi traditions. The novel brings Ambedkar's observation — that caste is not a division of labour but a division of labourers — to devastating life. It also complicates easy nationalist narratives around colonialism, centring the Battle of Bhima Koregaon and the Mahars who found emancipation where upper castes saw only humiliation.



Anand Teltumbde
Scholar, writer, activist

Ankit Kawade's *The Ambedkar and Nietzsche: Provocations* (Navayana) is a philosophically sophisticated work of comparative inquiry that

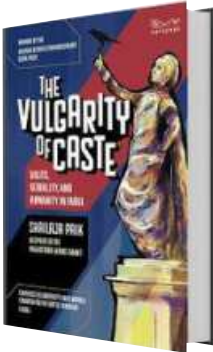
brings B.R. Ambedkar and Friedrich Nietzsche into a carefully mediated conversation without collapsing their profound differences. The book's originality lies in its methodological restraint: it does not seek facile reconciliation, but rather treats comparison as a way of generating new conceptual insight. By locating a shared problem — most strikingly, the question of how to read the *Manusmriti* — it opens up a rich terrain for thinking about domination, enslavement, morality, freedom, and the possibilities of radical politics. Particularly significant is its refusal to appropriate Ambedkar into depoliticised or politically convenient interpretive frameworks. Instead, the book preserves the distinctiveness and critical edge of Ambedkar's thought while using the friction of comparison to illuminate both thinkers anew. It is a rigorous and timely contribution to contemporary political philosophy, Ambedkar studies, and comparative intellectual history.



Suraj Yengde
Scholar, author, activist

Shailaja Paik's *The Vulgarly of Caste: Dalits, Sexuality, and Humanity in Modern India* (Navayana) provides a renewed focus on caste and the elasticity of

body by foregrounding western Maharashtra's vocabulary in the textual form. The author examines the gaze as both experience and the embodied territoriality of marginalised communities. This long labour of ethnography is written with independent authority, carefully balancing the study of a community with its aspirations for belonging in a changing society.



Sri Vamsi Matta
Interdisciplinary theatre artist

Untouchable Spring (Orient BlackSwan) by G. Kalyana Rao is an essential read. First published in Telugu in 2000 as *Antarani Vasantham*, it was translated in 2010 by Alladi Uma and M. Sridhar. I read it at the age of 17 or 18,

and returned to it a decade later while writing my first play. It is a novel, a kind of memoir, a family saga, and, to me, a Dalit epic.

The book traces seven generations of a Dalit family, reflecting the lives of the Mala and Madiga communities in Enneladinni, Andhra Pradesh. It interrogates dominant narratives around Dalit conversion to Christianity, highlighting the search for dignity, self-respect and education, even as caste discrimination persists in new forms. The book through its characters asserts that resistance is a necessity, not a choice. At its core, the book holds the memory of my people whose lives, culture, and histories are just like their spring — "untouchable".





Ina Puri

At the recently-concluded Kochi-Muziris Biennale (KMB), Ghanaian artist Ibrahim Mahama repurposed detritus of colonial/postcolonial infrastructure to reconstruct his much-discussed *Parliament of Ghosts* installation. I had first seen this work at the 2023 Venice Biennale. In Kochi, at the disused Anand Warehouse in Mattancherry, his chamber represented unrealised futures of Ghanaian independence and development; jute bags once used to transport pepper and timber became the walls, while chairs in various sizes and shapes lined up to create, over the course of the sixth edition of KMB, a site for book launches, workshops and public conversations. “The ghosts” are not only about loss,” says Mahama. “They are also about the persistence of unrealised possibilities... For me, the question is not how to rebuild the parliament that never fully existed, but how to imagine new forms of assembly and citizenship that emerge from the fragments we have inherited.” Mahama has directed the profits from his shows towards opening art institutions in his hometown of Tamale, Ghana: the Red Clay Studio, the Savannah Centre for Contemporary Art (SCCA) and



IN CONVERSATION

AGENTS OF TRANSFORMATION

Ghanaian artist Ibrahim Mahama, who topped 2025 *ArtReview*’s Power 100 list, talks about building a future from the ghosts of a colonial past

Nkrumah Volini, a space for exhibitions. Next month, the 38-year-old cultural figure will return to the world’s most important art event, Venice Biennale, where he will be part of a global line-up of artists engaging with themes of history, labour and postcolonial memory. At its 61st edition, Mahama will present a video work with the collective blaxTARLINES KUMASI. As a collateral event to the Biennale, he will also present in Venice his solo show *A Shea Garden*, developed in collaboration with Barovier & Toso and in partnership with Apalazzogallery, which has worked and collaborated with the artist since 2014. Excerpts from an interview:

Question: *Large-scale installations such as Parliament of Ghosts travel between sites in Ghana, Europe and India, bringing materials marked by local political histories into contact with new publics and regimes of display. How do you ensure that the work’s specificity is not flattened into a generic image of African crisis or resilience at international biennales and museums far from where those materials were first used?*

Answer: This is always a tension, and I don’t think it can ever be fully resolved. But for me, the work resists flattening through its material condition. These objects are not representations – they carry very specific traces: stains, smells, marks of use, inscriptions of labour. They

are evidence of particular histories, not symbols of a general condition. At the same time, I try to remain attentive to context. In some cases, like in India, it becomes important to work with materials that already exist there rather than simply transporting something from Ghana. This allows the work to enter into dialogue with local histories of labour and circulation, instead of fixing it within a single narrative. Also, the work functions as a space – [where] people sit, gather, speak. Meaning is not fixed by the image of the work but produced through encounters. The ‘ghosts’ are not a spectacle; they are activated through use, presence. I try to create conditions where the work’s



specificity continues to unfold, even as it moves across geographies.

Q: *Has your rise to the top of ArtReview magazine’s Power 100 list for 2025, as the first figure from the African continent to lead that ranking, made you, an artist from Tamale and Accra, rethink power?* What are the risks when an artist committed to decolonial and socialist imaginaries is celebrated by the very structures of Euro-American art world that once ignored such work?

A: The idea of power, for me, has very little to do with visibility or recognition



underlying structures. There is always a risk that the work becomes neutralised, or that it functions as a kind of representation rather than a tool for redistribution. The question is how to remain grounded. For me, that means ensuring the work continues to produce real conditions – education, access, infrastructure – rather than only circulating as an image. The capital generated through art has to be reinvested into building institutions and supporting communities, otherwise the idea of power becomes empty.

Q: *In your installation Garden of Scars at the Oude Kerk Amsterdam, you work with casts from Amsterdam’s gravestones to that of the floors of Ghana’s Fort Elmina, bringing different geographies and histories into a walkable field of fragments. How has making this work affected your own sense of what a scar can hold?*

A: In *Garden of Scars*, I work with casts of gravestones from both Amsterdam and Fort Elmina in Ghana, laying them across the floor like a field of memory. The floor itself is a site of collective history, where stories of merchants, colonisers, and the enslaved co-exist. The cracks, scars, and fractures in these stones are not just signs of decay – they are archives of lived histories, and when people walk over them, they become part of that conversation between past and present. The installation is not simply a historical recounting, but an invitation to think about how memory, loss, resilience, and future possibilities are all present in a single space.

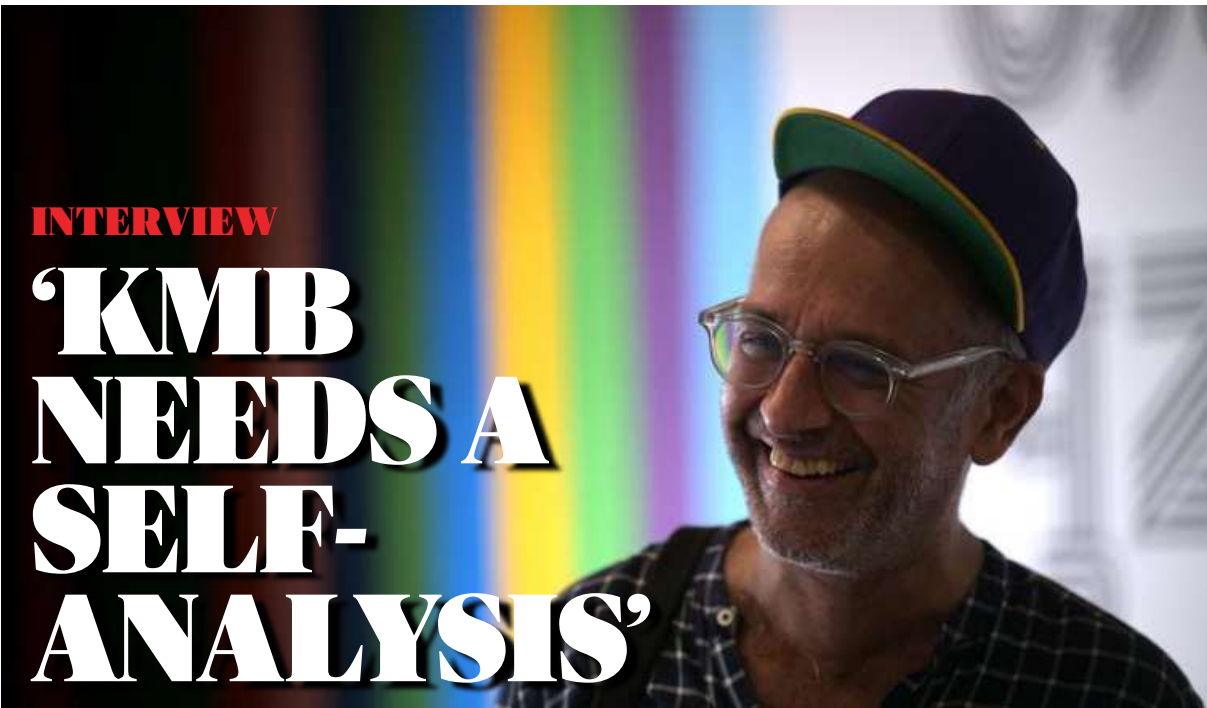
The writer is a Gurugram-based curator, author and collector.

Anoodha Kunnath

Nikhil Chopra is calm, if a little sweaty in Fort Kochi’s 34°C midday heat, as he walks into Aspinwall a week before the Kochi-Muziris Biennale officially ends. He tucks his cloth bag under a wooden chair, swaps his sunglasses for plain frames (for “eyes are the windows to the soul”, he jokes), and exchanges pleasantries with everyone present. The curator of the sixth edition of the Kochi-Muziris Biennale has been in Kerala since last August, and now with the end in sight, he is in the mood to discuss the highs, lows and surprises of the last few months, and his experience being a temporary local in a seaside town. “I think it’s a proud State, where everybody has a strong sense of identity and a desire to connect. What I’ve really enjoyed is making eye contact and taking the moment to say thank you,” he shares. “I know that if I come back, there will be many doors open to me, to hang out with each other.” With 66 artistic projects from 25 countries, working in high humidity and inside old derelict buildings, the 110 days of the exhibition have come with its fair share of difficulties. “There are horrific conditions around the world. So, even from an emotional place, for us to maintain our *raison d’être* has been a challenge. How do we create in a turbulent world – socially, economically and ecologically?” Edited excerpts from an exit interview.

Question: *Your response to why resources should be given to an art festival in fraught times like this?*

Answer: We hold up a mirror to the world; we reflect on the state of the world. It’s not just Iran, it’s also



With the Kochi-Muziris Biennale drawing to a close, curator Nikhil Chopra is ready to prepare a strong report to help his successor



The show must go on (Top) Artist and curator Nikhil Chopra; and a few installations from the Kochi-Muziris Biennale. (THULASI KAKKAT)

Gaza, Ukraine and Russia, Sudan, Venezuela. We are in a place where we need to be very worried about the state of this world. But if you don’t make art, don’t write poetry, don’t sing, don’t express yourself, then it is an opportunity lost. I’m of the belief as a performer that, no matter what, the show must go on. I like to think that what we are doing generates conversation and dialogue. We’re not here to decorate the walls of Kochi; we’re here to provoke conversations. We’re here to express our disagreement with the powers that be, challenge those powers, and use

the soft power that we have as artists and thinkers and cultural makers to use this moment to express ourselves.

Q: *Over these last few months, has anything surprised you?*

A: I think what surprised us was Island Warehouse. As a venue, we found ourselves having access to something that was so far away, and the freedom to imagine a completely different scale of the Biennale. That was probably one of the more risky aspects of what we’ve done as curators – to take the Biennale across the water. To bring

people into another dimension of this event, and not feel that we need to hang on to a certain kind of nostalgia with Fort Kochi and Mattancherry. It also gave us an opportunity to pave the way for where the Biennale will go.

Q: *KMB has rejoined the International Biennales Association. What are the non-negotiables to make it more stable and not lose its artist-led soul?*

A: Artists should [continue to] be at the centre of the Biennale. It is also essential that the foundation treats its six editions as an important manual. It’s now ready to create a

strong set of dos and don’ts as guardrails for the next curator. The Biennale needs to do a self-analysis in terms of what worked really well and where things can be better. And it needs to happen in a self-critical manner – not to beat oneself up about it, but to be progressive in the understanding of what this kind of civic responsibility means.

Q: *What do you think can be made better?*

A: The Biennale Foundation cannot afford to rest. It needs to run year-round, and have continuous engagement with the city. And that requires manpower, management, experience, and careful archiving. It also needs to create a system where the next curator has a lot of information for them to be able to fall back on, so that the same mistakes are not repeated again. I would be very happy to present a strong report, in which I am clear about what has been absolutely fantastic, what the gaps are, and where those gaps need to be filled. For instance, how the money is used – what funding is allocated for different aspects of the Biennale must be streamlined. I think this comes with experience. Also, it needs to exercise a sense of diligence. The city is important, but so is the artist. We invite their talent, their vulnerability, their labour, their politics to the exhibition. So, it is very important for the Biennale to consider the well-being of not just the artist but also of the people who are working to make that art.

(With inputs from Surya Praphulla Kumar)

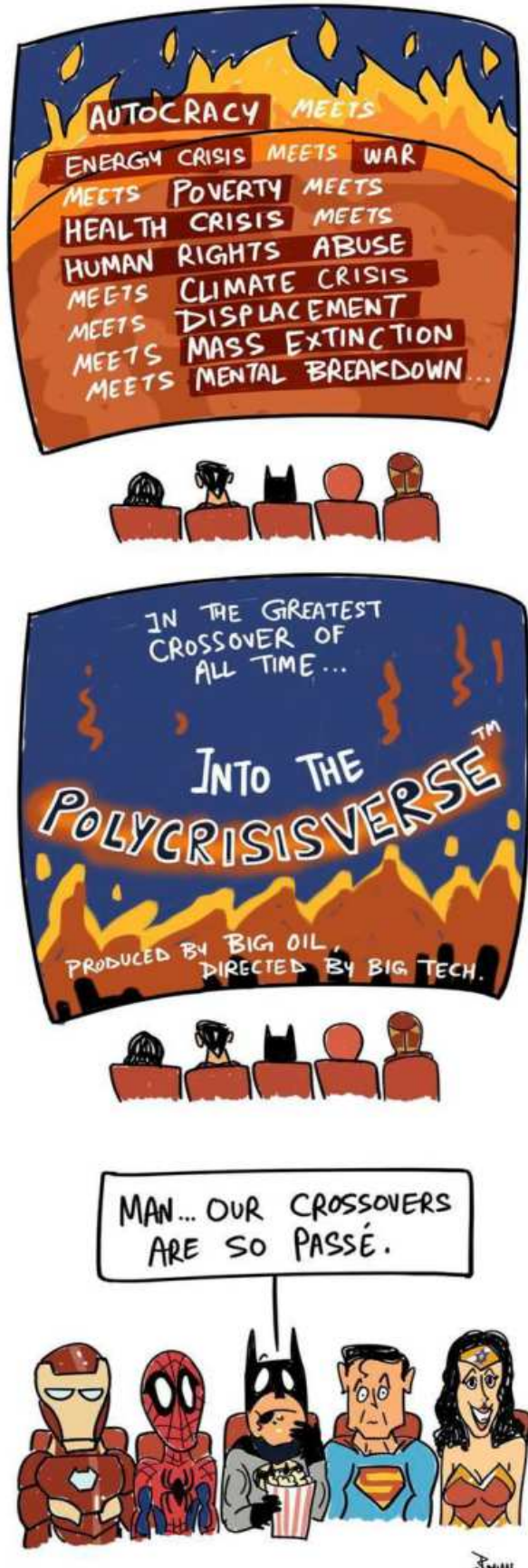
The interviewer is a Kochi-based filmmaker and director at Curiouser.



Scan the QR code to watch KMB curator Nikhil Chopra in conversation on magazine.thehindu.com

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

In Kerala, an AI-generated viral video shows world leaders, such as U.S. President Donald Trump, Russian President Vladimir Putin and French President Emmanuel Macron sporting traditional Kerala mundus and campaigning for various parties. While “Trump” is canvassing for the BJP, “Putin” is seen backing the Left Front while “Macron” asks for votes to the UDF, walking through busy Kerala streets. In West Bengal, both the ruling Trinamool Congress and its principal rival, the BJP, have used AI to create videos depicting each other’s leaders as the legendary *Sholay* character ‘Gabbar’, or, in one meme, more villainous than him. Yet, not all of it is humorous. In February, the X (formerly Twitter) account of BJP’s Assam unit posted an AI-generated video showing Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma shooting at two Muslim men with the caption “No mercy”. The video was pulled down after widespread condemnation. Last month, the Kerala Police filed an FIR against X and a user for uploading an AI-generated video featuring Modi and Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. Nath, the Twenty20 strategist, says they are steering clear of AI content. “We avoid AI-based content not only to ensure that we do not fall foul of regulatory mechanisms, but also to prevent a situation where the party’s credibility could be at stake

Threat vs. opportunity

Creators, in hushed tones, talk about how the rise in political content has opened the floodgates for money to flow into their pages, no matter what their following. While bigger names often get lucrative government contracts and advertisements, a Mumbai-based administrator of a popular meme page says political parties prefer working with micro-influencers having less than 100,000 followers. “Parties enlist such influencers to create memes around their rivals,” the admin says. “This content is never openly partisan, it’s often funny and entertaining, and works very well on Instagram.” Beyond such shadow wars that

FROM SELFIES TO SLOGAN



JAVAN G. NATH
Digital media campaign head, Twenty20



RANGARAJ PANDEY
Executive director, Center for the Study of Organized Hate



RAQIB NAIK
Executive director, Center for the Study of Organized Hate



MADRI KAKOTI
Academic, satirist



TALHA RASHID
Political consultant and strategist

gives you the tools to do so, from music to editing options,” she adds. Rashid, the political consultant, says Instagram’s short-form format is a double-edged sword. “Short-form videos cherry-pick facts and are often out-of-context, enabling them to easily seed false information,” he says. Trigger-happy users end up sharing such videos, amplifying the falsehood. Rahul Batra, ex-digital strategist at Google, who now works as a consultant on issues of technology and geopolitics, says companies such as Meta and Google are refusing to take responsibility for the content circulated on their platforms “like they did till 10 years ago”. “Basically, they have realised that this beast cannot be controlled centrally. Which is why they have decentralised content moderation,” he says, referring to the platforms increasingly toying the government line.

Will views translate to votes?

Multiple instances illustrate Instagram’s experience with governmental control. In February, independent media house *The Wire* saw its Instagram account blocked for two hours after it posted a political video cartoon critical of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Last week, a reel by stand-up comic Pulkit Mami, mimicking Modi’s meetings with foreign leaders, was taken down by Instagram on government orders, after it garnered over 16 million views.

Kakoti faced an FIR last year for her social media post criticising the media and the government’s response to the Pahalagam terrorist attack. Her DMs, both on Instagram and X, regularly see trolling, abuse, and even violent threats directed at her.

Batra, the ex-Google strategist, links such increasing censorship to the Gen Z protests that have taken place across the world. “Instagram has led to not just populist political campaigns but also populist uprisings,” he says. “Which is why, the same governments that were enjoying the social media phenomenon are now increasingly clamping down on it.” Naik, from CSOH, says “structural factors” inhabit Meta’s enforcement of its own guidelines. “Content moderation at scale requires deep local language capacity, and in the Indian context, investment in

trained reviewers and culturally informed systems remains far below what is needed.” A Meta spokesperson says it has “strict policies” against violent or graphic content that it enforces “impartially”. Meta also confirms that it has acted against content by restricting access to it in India “upon receipt of a valid legal order”. Such censorship and control over political messaging on the platform are unlikely to go unnoticed among voters. Pandey, the YouTube from Chennai, says voters look at short-form political content as “entertainment”. “Most of the social media viewers see this as entertainment. Instead of watching a TV show, they’d rather watch short political reels and memes,” he says, adding a cautionary note. “But more views don’t mean more votes.” An Amity University research paper last year, studying political engagement across three South Indian cities, Chennai, Hyderabad and Bengaluru, found just this. While 72% of Gen Z respondents regularly consume political content on Instagram, less than a fourth of them are actually motivated to engage in political participation, i.e. any action that can influence political systems and institutions. Rashid, the campaign strategist, agrees. “No matter how glitzy a candidate or party’s social media strategy is, the thumb rule is simple: if you are not on the ground, you won’t get the votes.” Voters such as Abish Puthusseray, a young IT professional in Kochi, concur. Puthusseray remains glued to his phone, with his main source of political news being Instagram. With the campaign season ongoing, political reels have “flooded” his feed. Yet, he says, the virality of these reels won’t shape electoral fortunes. “Viral Insta reels are not an indicator of the support base of a political front,” he says. “Voters here think long and hard before casting their votes. That’s how it works in Kerala.” (Name changed on request)

With inputs from S.R. Praveen in Kochi.

The Mumbai-based independent journalist is author of H-Pop: The Secretive World of Hindutva Pop Stars.



BINGE WATCH

A pirate flag, a protest

When the Straw Hat went from Netflix’s *One Piece* to pro-democracy protests

It is this devotion to individual liberty that has made *One Piece* such a potent symbol of anti-establishment protests in recent years. And the straw hat pirate flag kept recurring across countries. Last year, if Indonesian army seized these black flags with a hat-donning skull-and-bones pirate insignia – deemed a threat to national security – from houses, offices, protest meetings and cars passing by. French authorities confiscated these flags during widespread protests against the austerity measures proposed by Prime Minister François Bayrou. Netflix’s *One Piece* series has proven to be a hit among fans and critics alike, with Season 2 drawing rave reviews for its characterisation, world-building, special effects and action sequences. And through the

Serving individual freedom

Monkey is rebelling against the World Government, but also his own past. His estranged grandfather Garp (Vincent Regan), the navy vice-admiral, is a symbolic convergence of the family patriarch and the patriarchal head-of-state. So, in Monkey’s quest to becoming king of the pirates and live free in perpetuity, he is turning his back on several societal structures at once. In a similar vein, Zoro, at first, is being aggressively courted by the Baroque Works, a shadowy group of assassins. But he turns them down every time, even killing a junior member sent to parlay with him. Individual freedom is highlighted again with a line Zoro repeats thrice in the first episode: “I’ve kinda got my own thing going on”. Everywhere you look in *One Piece*, you find likeable, sympathetic characters who are trapped by larger societal forces outside of their control. And control is what they want to wrest. The resourceful Nami (Emily Rudd), highly skilled in cartography, is tired of being told that being a pirate is a man’s game. She wants to map the known world – which, for an authoritarian government, is a major offence. Tyrants everywhere seek to control the flow of information. Sanji (Taz Skylar) is looking for the mythical “All Blue”, a convergence point in the oceans that may hold the key to freedom from the World Government. What makes *One Piece* a universally beloved franchise? Are these stories about a group of misunderstood young people looking at an archaic, broken world and seeking to fix it in their own way, the rallying cry of the straw hat pirate isn’t merely a call to arms. It is shorthand for systemic change, and therein lies the true appeal of *One Piece*.

Aditya Mami Jha is working on his first book of non-fiction.

Krithi Karanth spent a lot of her childhood being silent, sitting on wooden benches in metal watchtowers soaring above sprawling forests, with her father Ullas Karanth, a conservation scientist and tiger expert. “For six hours a day, I’d have to just sit there,” recalls Krithi, 47. “He didn’t even let me carry a story book or a Walkman. It was literally lunch, a pair of binoculars, and a ‘sit here and watch’. You do this almost 17 years of your life and it does something to your brain, right?”

It certainly rewired the way Krithi viewed the world – with a lot of patience. Had she not been a conservation biologist, she might have become an architect or an interior designer, but the scientific community is richer for people like her.

In 28 years, she has won at least 50 awards, most recently becoming the first Indian to win the prestigious Esmond B. Martin Royal Geographical Society Prize in the U.K. An adjunct professor at Duke University and CEO of the Centre for Wildlife Studies (CWS) in Bengaluru, an organisation founded by her father 42 years ago, her work examines the interactions between humans and animals, with a focus on co-existence and empathy. Let’s call them her rules of co-existence.

Right to exist
Krithi, who spends a few days in the wild every month, knows that children are always the best place to start. “Our children get excited about kangaroos and lions and giraffes, but if you ask them about a *gaur* or a lion-tailed macaque, they have very little knowledge, right?” she says. “So what can we do to



PERSON OF INTEREST

KRITHI KARANTH: RULES OF CO-EXISTENCE

The conservation biologist on why children are key to building awareness of human-animal interactions

build curiosity and excitement?” That was the starting point of her conversations with environmentalist Gabby Salazar in 2017, at a time when India desperately needed to discuss the fading of its last wild spaces and species. Their ‘Wild Shaale’ programme is now taught in 1,600 government schools to more than 71,000 children across the Eastern and Western Ghats, the latter being one of the world’s

leading biodiversity hotspots, and struggling to survive relentless human incursions. Krithi’s children, 18 and 10, often travel with her and they have learnt to sit still, too. The Wild Shaale programme

Krithi Karanth is CEO of the Centre for Wildlife Studies in Bengaluru.

builds empathy, curiosity, and shows children why they need to share space with other species. An elephant foraging game (with poker chips to represent food and water), for example, helps them understand how much elephants consume (an adult eats 200-250 kg of grass/fodder every day). At the end of the game, the children count their tokens to see if they collected enough to survive. “They realise how much elephants need to eat and why crop damage happens,” says Krithi, adding that Indian children score high on empathy assessment scales.

“Most Indians have this fundamental belief that animal life has a right to exist,” she says. “We are much more in tune with the fact that there is non-human life out there.” And, yet, India ranked fourth from the bottom out of 180 countries in the 2024 Nature Conservation Index. Krithi’s work is important in a world where the average size of monitored wildlife populations has declined 73% in the 50 years to 2020 (source: World Wide Fund for Nature).

Building trust
Krithi’s LinkedIn profile describes her as a conservation optimist and while she knows that the battles have intensified, she sees the silver linings: broader public support, greater recognition that the environment matters, and more funding. “If you look at the number of people in this country who care for the environment, for animals, that number has grown,” she says.

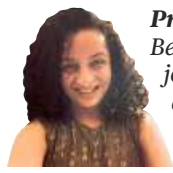
Thanks to the Internet, even those who don’t see animals in the wild can appreciate their importance. “Information access is more equal than it was before,” she says. “That gives you an opportunity to create more people who are going to do stuff for nature.”

She contrasts the loneliness of the early environmentalist with a wider community of invested people today. “It’s very apparent to me that people just know more,” she says.

Krithi’s mindset is that of a marathoner and not a sprinter. “You keep going three steps forward, two steps back. You have to be resilient and gritty, not get overly joyous when something works, and then, when it slides back, go into this doom and gloom scenario,” she says. To see her name on a scientific paper, to witness children participate, and to see ideas succeed are all small joys for her.

CWS’ Wild Seve programme, where people can reach out for ground support with any human-animal conflict through a toll free number, is now in its 11th year and thriving in 30 wildlife parks. It offers support to rural Indians on the frontline of wildlife conservation efforts. Krithi jokes that her team could easily win elections because they are consistent and reliable. “That builds faith and confidence in people,” she says. “And I think trust is so much in deficit today.”

Priya Ramani is a Bengaluru-based journalist and the co-founder of India Love Project on Instagram.



GOREN BRIDGE

A fine duck
Neither vulnerable, West deals

Bob Jones

South’s two no-trump bid in this balancing position is a wide-ranging bid. South could have had much less for the bid. North had to raise with his hand, hoping South could find nine tricks. South had 17 points, but he had his hands full with this one. Many would cover the jack of hearts lead with dummy’s queen. South saw that he would need a trick or two from the

diamond suit. If he played the queen of hearts at trick one and East had the ace of diamonds, East would win the ace at some point and return his remaining heart and the contract would fail. Should West have the ace of diamonds, he could not also have the king of spades for his weak two bid, so the contract could not be made whatever South did. South decided to play low from dummy on the opening lead and he also played low from his hand. West continued with the ace and

NORTH
♠ A J 7
♥ Q 6
♦ 7 6 5 4
♣ Q J 9 3
WEST
♠ 8
♥ A J 10 8 5 2
♦ J 8 3
♣ 6 5 2
SOUTH
♠ Q 5 3 2
♥ K 9 4
♦ K Q 9
♣ A K 4
EAST
♠ K 10 9 6 4
♥ 7 3
♦ A 10 2
♣ 10 8 7

The bidding:
WEST NORTH EAST SOUTH
2♥ Pass 3NT
Pass All pass

Opening lead: Jack of ♥

another heart. South won with the king and led a spade to dummy’s jack. East took the king and shifted to a club. Declarer won in hand with the ace and led a spade to dummy’s ace. A low diamond to his king

won the trick. South cashed the king of clubs, led a club to dummy’s queen, and cashed the jack of clubs while discarding a low spade. A diamond toward his queen got him his ninth trick. Well played!

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

All about symbols and signs



Berty Ashley

This symbol was commissioned for the British Campaign for Nuclear Disarmament. It combines semaphore signals for ‘N’ (nuclear) and ‘D’ (disarmament). Designed by Gerald Holtom, it was said to represent human despair, with arms held downwards. First seen during a protest march on April 4-5, 1958, what is this symbol better known as?

In 2010, a nationwide design contest was announced, and from 3,331 entries, this symbol was selected. Designed by Udaya Kumar, a professor at IIT Guwahati, it cleverly incorporates

both Devanagari and Latin elements. What is this now-ubiquitous symbol?

This symbol was originally called *punctus admirativus*. It likely evolved from the word ‘io’, used to express joy. It later became a common punctuation mark used to end sentences. What is this symbol?

These important signs are typically red or green in colour. While most display a four-letter word in capital letters, some feature a pictogram of a running figure. What sign is this, vital in emergencies?

This app is designed so that pictures and messages are

accessible only for a brief period before disappearing. Its logo features a ghost whose name is inspired by Ghostface Killah, a member of the hip-hop group Wu-Tang Clan. What popular app is this?

This symbol consists of a trefoil around a small central circle. Designed in 1946, it was originally placed on a blue background as an ‘information’ sign, but later changed to yellow to indicate hazard. What sign is this that shows dangerous ions/particles are present?

This symbol originates from 16th-century manuscripts as an abbreviation of the Latin word *recipe*, meaning ‘receive’ or ‘take’.

Now commonly seen in formal communication from a particular profession, what symbol is this, often written as Rx?

This iconic symbol was designed in 1913 by the founder of the organisation, officially introduced in 1914 and first used in 1920. The six colours represented those found in all national flags at the time. Later, it was interpreted as representing the continents. What is this symbol?

This symbol is one of the oldest known representations and has remained largely unchanged. Since the Middle Ages, it has been a hazard symbol. Originally depicted using real elements, since the 18th century, it has appeared on flags and military insignia. What infamous symbol is this?

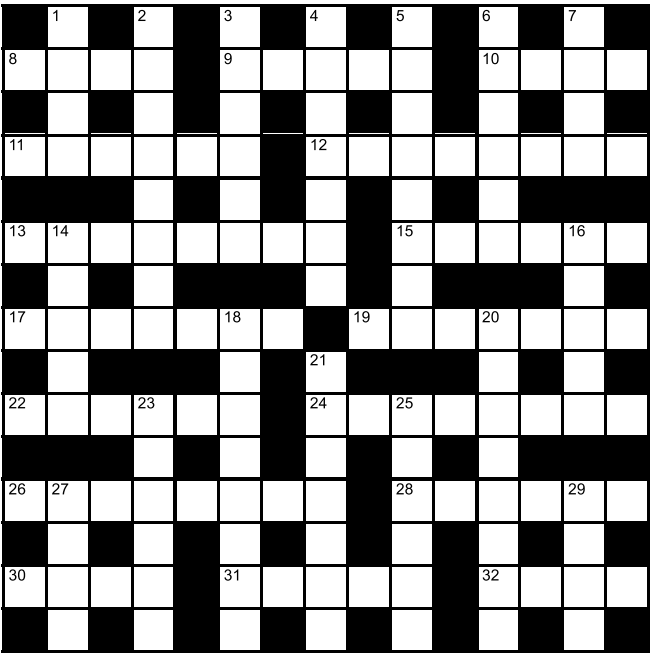
When the first Earth Day was celebrated in 1970, the Container Corporation of America sponsored a design competition for a symbol. The winning design featured three chasing arrows forming a continuous loop, resembling a Möbius strip. What is this symbol?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’. @bertyashley

- 1. Peace symbol
- 2. Indian rupee
- 3. An exclamation mark
- 4. Exit sign
- 5. Snapchat
- 6. Radioactive
- 7. Prescription
- 8. Olym pics
- 9. Skull and crossbones
- 10. Recycle symbol

Answers

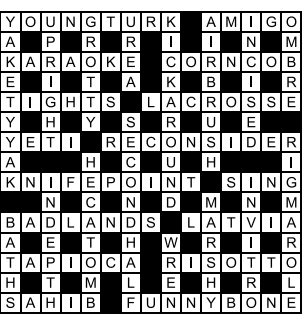
THE SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 50



- Across**
- 8 Bread? That’s mine, and accompanied by a bit of anchovy (4)
 - 9 Hides peels (5)
 - 10 Caretaker’s mails lost in Himalayas, surprisingly (4)
 - 11 Capital possessed by Shankar Acharya (6)
 - 12 See Luke going mad about learner’s musical instruments (8)
 - 13 Recommend, “Do vacate anyhow” (8)
 - 15 Using machine for putting down on paper and mistakenly taping using Yankee instead of American (6)
 - 17 Harmful constituent of food animal consumed, taking in a lot at first (7)
 - 19 Lands in the lakes? (7)
 - 22 Cancel north eastern entrance (6)
 - 24 Expectorated on university luncheonette assistant initially and started soiling pancake flippers (8)
 - 26 Compose march tune in lounge chair, perhaps (8)
 - 28 Except Australian neon gas (6)
 - 30 Small piece available in Kanchipuram (4)
 - 31 Drink first, followed by setter’s game (5)
 - 32 Queen present in Tehran, Iran (4)

- 5 A message of distress about most superior material that is harmful (8)
- 6 What the lady did to improve looks to get edam? (4,2)
- 7 23 in Kalpetta, Kerala (4)
- 14 Die around 9 or 11 for southern part of the U.S. (5)
- 16 Diana? Could be a Comaneci... (5)
- 18 Books confused Thai user (8)
- 20 True, lady is excited in extra-marital affair (8)
- 21 Has spread butter with a bit of salt in monasteries (7)
- 23 Take small quantity covered with peat mixture (6)
- 25 Sailor accompanies Turkish governor at small monasteries (6)
- 27 Some leaving Rushmore for German area (4)
- 29 6 doing headstand? (4)

SOLUTION NO. 49



The courage to ask

Professional excellence thrives only if there is an environment where questioning is not seen as defiance but as engagement

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Of all the memories from my schooldays, one regret stands out sharply: I did not ask enough questions. Like most of my classmates, I listened quietly, scribbled notes, and accepted whatever was taught as settled truth. We were obedient learners, not curious ones. At the time, silence felt like discipline. With hindsight, it was a missed opportunity.

This realisation returned to me recently at a seminar on the India-Pakistan war of 1947-48 – the first major military operation fought by the Indian Army after Independence. I had prepared thoroughly, revisiting books and archival accounts. Yet, despite extensive reading, several doubts lingered in my mind. I was looking forward to the interactive session mentioned in the programme – a rare opportunity to engage eminent panellists and seek clarity.

The schedule clearly allotted 30 minutes for questions and answers. On the day of the event, I listened intently, waiting for that session. To my surprise, it was quietly dropped. During the tea break, when I asked the organiser about it, he casually replied that it was not really required; it had merely been included in the printed programme as a formality.

That moment was disappointing, but it was also revealing. It underlined a deeper issue in our culture – we often undervalue inquiry. We speak, we lecture, we deliver presentations. But we rarely encourage dialogue.

I have noticed a curious pattern in many gatherings. After a lecture, when someone gathers the courage to ask a question, the entire audience shifts in their seats, craning their necks to see who is speaking. The attention shifts from the substance of the question to the identity of the questioner. It betrays a subtle discomfort with curiosity.

Yet questions are the lifeblood of progress. Without them, knowledge becomes static. With them, it evolves.

In every profession – be it education, the armed



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

forces, medicine, or administration – learning does not end with instruction. It deepens through discussion. Particularly in the military, lessons from past operations must be examined threadbare within the system. While operational secrecy must always be preserved, critical analysis and candid questioning strengthen institutions. They prevent complacency.

Open discussion

I witnessed this culture first-hand during my tenure in Lebanon in 2007 while commanding 15 Punjab. I attended a military seminar in Israel, and what struck me most was not the sophistication of the presentations, but the openness of the discussion. Junior officers – men and women – confidently questioned senior Generals. Their queries were sharp, thoughtful, and sometimes challenging. No one looked around to identify who was speaking. All ears were tuned to the merit of the idea. Rank did not silence curiosity, but welcomed it.

That experience left a lasting impression. It showed me that professional excellence thrives in an environment where questioning is not seen as defiance but as engagement.

We, too, must cultivate that spirit – beginning at home and in schools. Curiosity should not be

mistaken for indiscipline. Children who ask questions are not being difficult; they are learning to think. Parents must resist the temptation to silence persistent queries with impatience. Teachers must tolerate even the so-called “irritating” questions. Often, those are the ones that push boundaries.

The habit of questioning should extend beyond classrooms. In daily life, we must ask why things are done a certain way, whether there is a better alternative, whether established practices still serve their purpose. Progress comes not from blind agreement but from thoughtful examination.

There is a simple metaphor that captures this idea. We can choose to be like a pond – still, contained, and eventually stagnant. Or we can be like the ocean – constantly moving, renewing itself with fresh currents. Questions are those currents. They keep institutions vibrant and individuals intellectually alive.

The courage to ask is as important as the ability to answer. It begins in childhood but must be nurtured throughout life. When we encourage enquiry, we cultivate independent thinkers rather than passive recipients of information.

In the end, societies that question grow stronger. Those that remain silent risk stagnation. The choice, like the question, is ours.

The fine line between duty and responsibility

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When I told my mother that it was our duty to take care of our parents, she gently responded, perhaps with a touch of pain, “Is it only a duty... nothing more?”

I had never thought there was anything wrong with the word “duty”. Later, my brother-in-law suggested, “You could have said responsibility.” It sounded warmer. My mother, too, seemed satisfied with it.

In an official atmosphere, we perform our work sincerely as part of our duty. Even if we do not fully agree with our superior’s ideas, we carry out tasks for the smooth functioning of the organisation. A duty demands completion, often within a deadline, whether or not our heart is fully involved.

Responsibility, however, feels different. It is carried out with willingness and inner acceptance. It considers the influence a person or an institution has had on our lives. Responsibility arises from reciprocity – and reciprocity, ideally, should be born out of love. It includes emotional involvement and physical support, not merely obligation. When we speak of duty, we often associate it with official roles and, at times, with monetary compensation. Responsibility, on the other hand, is rooted in affection, gratitude, and moral commitment.

Yet I still wonder, “Can responsibility not exist in an official atmosphere?” Certainly it can. When we think beyond instructions, when we act for the long-term good of the organisation despite immediate pressures, our duty transforms into responsibility. Similarly, at home, caring for parents in a routine or rotational manner may appear as duty. But when we strive to understand their unspoken expectations and ensure their comfort with love and patience, it becomes responsibility.

Groaning under too much information

Consumption of vast amounts of digital content leads to a fragmented understanding of the world

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A significant yet rarely acknowledged downside of social media is the overconsumption of information. We are not an information starved society any more, and in ideal terms, this should have been a great victory for humanity, but social media has somehow managed to spoon-feed opinions. Our ideas, standards, opinions and taste are dictated by reels.

Short-form content is ruling our lives, and we are slaves to endless scrolling.

We as a society have become gluttons for content. Our lives are full of opinions, rants, preachings and commentaries, we are rarely uninformed, yet one has to ask if we are truly informed.

This short-form content feels rewarding to watch; one does not have to put in any form of mental labour to reach the point. Our ideas are formed for us, our opinions dictated,



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we are merely told what to think. This content also governs a huge part of our social life, it decides what is chic and what is cringe, what one should have, to fit in and what makes one odd. We react before we understand. Here the distinction between what nourishes our mind and what merely stimulates it, becomes blurred.

Social media pumps us up with dopamine while failing to add any value in

our lives. Much of the digital space revolves around four main spheres: gossip, memes, politics, and influencing. Gossip offers fleeting amusement, memes generally reduce complex issues into instantly digestible fragments, political content instead of cultivating civic understanding rewards outrage, and influencing packages consumption as aspiration. None of this content is inherently harmful, yet when these forms dominate our intellectual intake our mind starts to mirror it making us restless, reactive, and fragmented.

Hence in a world that is obsessed with counting calories, count your thoughts and ideas and when you do, remember to hold on to them. So put yourself in an information diet, and be intentional about your content consumption.

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I did not realise when my thumb acquired a mind of its own, even a philosophy. Perhaps it followed a simple rule of thumb and moved ahead without consulting me. The revelation struck me one morning. I had sent a long, carefully worded message. It contained context, sincerity, perhaps even literary ambition. I pressed send and waited with reasonable optimism. The reply arrived in seconds – a solitary “thumbs-up emoji”.

Calm and confident

Yes, no words, no explanation, no sentence. Just a yellow thumb standing upright, calm and confident, and as if by

Thumbing through meaningful emojis

The like/dislike icons aren’t lazy; yet, it should supplement, not supplant, words



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some universal thumb rule, the matter stood concluded.

A psychological marvel of our age, and perhaps its most misunderstood gesture, the emoji offers validation without the onus of involvement. The brain accepts it the way a ticket checker nods after a brief glance. Message sent. Response received. Job

done. Dopamine released. For the sender, it says, “I acknowledge you.” For the receiver, it quietly adds, “Please do not ask me to elaborate.”

Emotionally, the thumb works like a multi-signal junction. It can mean agreement, support, approval, dismissal, or silent judgment. Context does the heavy lifting.

When my boss sends it, my shoulders relax. When a close friend sends it after I pour my heart out, my pulse quickens. Same thumb. Entirely different blood pressure.

Our ancestors read omens in the skies. We read meaning in a pixel.

Escape hatch

Socially, the thumbs-up has become a polite escape hatch. In family WhatsApp groups, it dodges arguments without sounding rude. In office groups, it avoids commitment while looking professional. In school parent groups, it replaces attendance. “Tomorrow is fancy dress day.” Twenty thumbs appear, five wake up at midnight wondering what on earth their child is supposed to dress as.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

It is heartening to see Indian researchers revisit the intriguing Jeewanu experiments, a subject of global scientific significance yet long overlooked. (‘Second life’; March 29) Such work reflects the quiet perseverance of hard-working people. India’s scientific sector deserves greater visibility.

Harsh Pawaria

Coming from a developing country, Krishna Bahadur’s discovery was not taken seriously. Many in developed nations dismissed his work, assuming that experiments conducted with simple equipment lacked scientific rigour. Fortunately, time has brought recognition. This story shows that truth ultimately prevails even though bureaucratic hurdles and narrow mindsets often make the path more difficult.

S. Sundareswara Pandiyan

The cover story offers a compelling examination of the contrasts in research efforts between developing and developed nations. It is particularly disheartening to learn that a groundbreaking discovery was neglected, with little clarity offered as to why this oversight occurred.

Sajna Hameed

Essential reading

Sumana Mukherjee’s review is both touching and precise in its choice of words. (‘An elegy for a syncretic world’; March 29) Her concluding remark — “and in the process, makes each of us a little bit more human again” — is deeply thought-provoking. It highlights the impact of



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The quiet politics of a prefix

Language influences gender perception in ways that go undetected

Lubna Khanam

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Annora Alex

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The epic gives new messages in every new reading

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